

THE THICK REDLINES

WITH LEFT PARTIES
PUSHING FOR MUCH
TOUGHER ASSURANCES,
THE GOVERNMENT WILL
FIND THE LAST MILE
EVEN HARDER TO CROSS.
A LONG PAUSE COULD
PROVE FATAL.

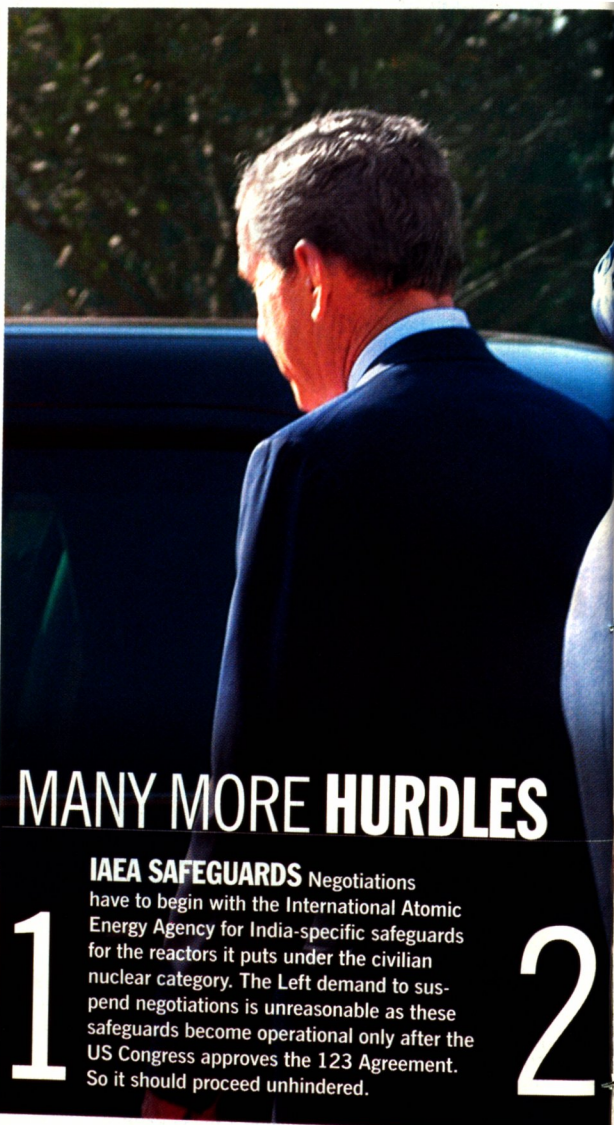
■ By Raj Chengappa

To maintain transparency on the Indo-US nuclear deal, the UPA Government made the terms of the 123 Agreement public in the last week of July. Some in the Government had argued then that it would have been better to have waited till Parliament convened a fortnight later and to have tabled its contents in the House. As a rationale for releasing it before that, a senior Ministry of External Affairs official quoted Lady Macbeth: "If it were done when 'tis done, then 'twere well it were done quickly."

In retrospect, that allusion was perhaps inappropriate. For the BJP was the first to cry that India's nuclear sovereignty was sought to be murdered under the 123 Agreement. The Left parties followed soon after by broadening the attack and charging the Government with making India a vassal to the US. Prime Minister Manmohan Singh then delivered his "lump it or leave" threat. So even before Parliament was convened, the positions had hardened. When Prakash Karat, the CPI(M) general secretary, imperiously told the Government not to proceed with the operationalisation of the deal or face "serious political consequences", the Government was truly in a bind. Were the Left parties demanding a pause to review the deal or was it meant to kill it altogether?

Killing the deal was not an option for the Government. If it does happen, it would be the first time since Independence that a Government would be reneging from an agreement with another country. The impact, as Lalit Mansingh, a former foreign secretary, puts it, "would be massively negative. Both the prime minister and the Government would lose face and India's credibility in the international arena would suffer. There would be questions not just by the US but other industrialised nations also as to how serious is India about being a global player." He also

BACKLASH: Bush and Manmohan face opponents at home even though there's no scope for renegotiation



MANY MORE HURDLES

IAEA SAFEGUARDS Negotiations have to begin with the International Atomic Energy Agency for India-specific safeguards for the reactors it puts under the civilian nuclear category. The Left demand to suspend negotiations is unreasonable as these safeguards become operational only after the US Congress approves the 123 Agreement. So it should proceed unhindered.

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